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Art As Protest: The Untold Story of African Art

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Movements Fueling Social Change "Every mural, every drumbeat, every brushstroke is a rebellion written in color." – Adapted from African proverb-inspired thought

In Khartoum, Sudan, a spray-painted hand rises from the wall of the city morgue, tagged with the word “missing.” This haunting mural is a memorial to protesters slain during the 2019 Sudanese revolution – a stark reminder of hundreds of lives lost and still unaccounted for.

Across Africa, art has long been more than just aesthetic expression; it has been a lifeline of protest and hope for oppressed communities. From covert symbols woven into textiles to murals that scream for justice on public walls, African artists have continuously harnessed creativity as a weapon against injustice. This article shines light on how African art movements, past and present, have fueled social change – blending passion, resilience, and creativity to challenge the status quo.

Cultural Resistance Under Colonial Rule Even under the yoke of colonialism, Africans found ways to resist through art and culture. When direct political dissent was brutally suppressed, creative expression became a subtle weapon of defiance. For example, Enoch Sontonga’s hymn “Nkosi Sikelel’ iAfrika,” composed in 1897, evolved into a stirring anthem of African liberation that rallied the oppressed

Throughout the continent, traditional art forms – folk songs, dances, masquerades, carvings – carried coded messages of resilience and unity. These early instances of art as protest laid the groundwork for the more overt cultural revolutions that would accompany Africa’s independence struggles.

Art and the Fight for Independence As African nations pushed toward independence in the mid-20th century, artists were at the forefront of cultural liberation. They rejected colonial artistic norms and reasserted African identity through new styles and movements. In 1958, a group of art students in Nigeria formed the Zaria Art Society – soon nicknamed the “Zaria Rebels” – to challenge the dominance of European art training. They embraced a philosophy of “natural synthesis,” fusing indigenous aesthetics with Western techniques.

Jimo Akolo’s The Conspiracy

Across the continent, similar currents emerged: in Senegal, President Léopold Senghor championed the Négritude movement, encouraging artists to celebrate African heritage as a

form of anti-colonial pride. In these struggles, art became both a mirror – reflecting the people's dreams of freedom – and a hammer to help forge those dreams into reality.

Resistance Art in the Apartheid Era Nowhere was the power of art as protest more evident than in apartheid-era South Africa. During the dark decades of institutionalized racial oppression (1948–1994), art provided a voice to the silenced majority. In fact, works created in this period came to be known as "resistance art" – art that "lost its innocence," directly confronting the injustices of the state without restraint. Read more… Paintings, poems, songs, and photographs became weapons, as creatives used paint and words as tools of liberation. The apartheid regime understood the threat. It labeled dissident art as subversive and, under draconian laws like the Suppression of Communism Act, persecuted countless artists through censorship, exile, imprisonment, and even torture. Yet repression only emboldened these cultural warriors. In 1961, artist Ronald Harrison unveiled "The Black Christ," a painting that portrayed South Africa's Prime Minister as a crucifier of Black people. The government banned and attempted to destroy the painting, and Harrison was brutally tortured in custody for daring to make such a statement. Collective efforts also emerged. The Medu Art Ensemble, for example, was a multiracial, Pan-African collective of cultural workers formed in exile in Botswana after the 1976 Soweto uprising. Medu (meaning "roots") produced underground newsletters and bold posters that were smuggled into South Africa, rallying people with powerful messages of unity and defiance. These posters – with vivid imagery – helped bolster Black consciousness and international solidarity against apartheid. Artists such as Willie Bester and Sue Williamson, meanwhile, crafted searing visual commentaries on apartheid's cruelty in the 1980s, their works denouncing the racist regime and contributing to growing global outrage. Resistance art became "the voice of the silenced," uniting the oppressed and fueling their resolve. These cultural acts of defiance helped bring South Africa's day of liberation closer. Art in Contemporary Movements and Social Change Aisha Yesufu, a prominent activist, stands with her fist raised at an #EndSARS protest in Abuja (2020), in an iconic photograph by Victor Odiba

Such images became symbols of the youth-driven movement against police brutality in Nigeria.

In West Africa, a vibrant convergence of art and activism has challenged corruption and injustice. Nigeria's recent #EndSARS protests against police brutality are a case in point. As demonstrations swept the nation in 2020, a creative wave accompanied the chants and marches. Street murals, digital illustrations, protest songs and spoken-word performances all bloomed in solidarity. Young artists painted poignant tributes to victims and powerful calls for reform on Lagos city walls. Musicians followed suit – from Afrobeat legend Fela Kuti to today's pop stars – all lending their voices with protest songs that energized the movement. "As the protest went on, artists began to sympathize and express themselves through music,

performance, photography, drawing, painting, and other forms of art," one observer noted, describing an outpouring of creativity that amplified and memorialized the movement's spirit. The fusion of art and activism helped transform a series of street protests into a broader cultural awakening. Even when security forces opened fire on peaceful demonstrators at Lagos's Lekki Toll Gate, protesters defiantly held up flags and sang – a heartbreaking scene now immortalized in artwork and song.

A political mural by graffiti artist "Medo" on a Khartoum morgue wall, painted during Sudan's 2019 revolution. The outstretched hand labeled "Missing" symbolizes protesters killed or disappeared by the regime. In Sudan, too, artists fueled a revolution. During the monumental 2018–2019 protests that toppled dictator Omar al-Bashir, Khartoum's walls exploded with art. Hundreds of murals sprang up across the capital, honoring slain demonstrators as martyrs and condemning the crimes of the former regime. At the massive sit-in outside military headquarters, protesters turned the space into an open-air gallery – painting, singing, performing – until the sit-in was brutally dispersed by paramilitary forces on June 3, 2019. In the aftermath, young Sudanese creatives like Medo "kept the spirit of the sit-ins alive" by continuing to paint murals that demanded justice and preserved the memory of the fallen. "All we can continue to do is make art because things are too bad," Medo explained, underscoring how art remained one of the few outlets for hope amid turmoil. Beyond these headline-making movements, countless African artists are driving social change on various fronts. In South Africa, visual activist Zanele Muholi uses photography to challenge LGBTQ+ stigma, while Mozambican sculptor Gonçalo Mabunda transforms civil-war weapons into powerful artworks for peace and reconciliation.

Goncalo Mabunda, The Throne of the Living , 2020 From human rights to environmental crises, African creatives continue to turn pain into purpose, often at personal risk – sparking dialogue and empathy through their work. Notably, the impact of African protest art reverberates far beyond Africa's borders. African art has even influenced international movements like Black Lives Matter, which echoes the bold visuals and messages honed in African protest. The language of protest art is now global – yet its heartbeat remains in Africa, where struggle is met with imagination and art continues to ignite change.

Here's My Conclusion For over a century, African artists have risked censorship, exile – even life itself – to speak truth to power through brushstrokes, beats, and storytelling, proving that creativity can be a powerful catalyst for change. They have exposed injustices, healed communities, and kept the flames of hope burning during the darkest nights. Today, a new generation is taking up this mantle with fresh voices and visions. African artists will undoubtedly keep turning pain into purpose and art into action, lighting the way toward a more just world.

Why This Story Lives on Makolaa

At Makolaa, we believe that business, art, and culture are not separate threads, they are the fabric of our collective future.

Art as Protest is more than history; it is proof that creativity can be a weapon for change, a shield for dignity, and a language for those the world often refuses to hear. By telling these stories, we honor the makers, the dreamers, and the disruptors who turn resistance into legacy. Because for us, every stroke of paint and every raised voice is not just protest… it is possibility.